In 1916 an Arab army was raised and led by Prince Faisal, the son of the Sharif of Mecca. The army blew up Turkish trains and disrupted the flow of military supplies to the Turkish soldiers. This became known as the Arab Revolt. The activities of this Arab army are well known because an English army intelligence officer, Major T.E. Lawrence, who became known in Britain as 'Lawrence of Arabia', fought with the Arabs. In 1918, Faisal and his Arab soldiers were allowed by the British to march in and take the city of Damascus, in Syria, from the Turks.

Key dates

The Arab Revolt: 1916

Sykes–Picot Agreement: 1916

Britain granted mandate over Palestine: 1919

The Sykes–Picot Agreement 1916

The Arabs felt that they had fought for their independence from the Turks and now deserved complete self-government. Arab leaders were therefore angered when they heard that Britain and France had secretly agreed, in 1916, to carve up Turkey's Arab lands after the war and share them out between themselves. This agreement is known as the Sykes–Picot Agreement after the British and French politicians who made it. Under the agreement, some Arab land would be directly ruled by Britain or France while the rest would be Arab states with either Britain or France having some indirect control over them.

Why did the British make this agreement?

- The war in Europe (against Germany) was not going well and it was vital for Britain to maintain a strong alliance with France, its main ally in the war.
- Both Britain and France had extensive trading links with the Middle East.
- Britain wanted to protect the Suez Canal, which was jointly owned and operated with the French. The Canal was the main route to Britain's empire in India and to the recently discovered oilfields in the Persian Gulf (see map on page 9). Britain already controlled Egypt and saw Palestine as an additional buffer zone to protect the Canal and the route to the east.

To sum up, Britain and France wished to maintain their power and influence in the Middle East and they saw the Sykes–Picot Agreement as an important step to achieving this.

Key term

Mandate
An order or command, in this case from the League of Nations, giving Britain and France control of Arab lands previously ruled by Turkey. Britain and France were to prepare the Arab lands for eventual self-government.

British and French mandates in the Middle East

Arab fears were confirmed in 1919. In the Treaty of Versailles, which followed the end of the First World War, Britain and France were given **mandates**, or orders, to govern certain countries in the Middle East until the Arab people were considered ready to govern themselves. Britain was given mandates over Palestine, Transjordan (later known as Jordan) and Iraq, and British troops and government officials took control of these lands. France was granted mandates over Syria and Lebanon and sent troops in to take control.

Key question

Why did Britain and France want mandates in the Middle East?